‘When Indian intelligence was hunting for assets inside Afghanistan, they saw that the government was pushing for several reforms, including literacy, in most parts of the country, and an academy of sciences was inaugurated in Kabul on 21 February 1979. A delegation led by Vasili Arkhipov, Soviet first deputy premier, paid a brief visit to Kabul from 27 February to 1 March 1979 and several agreements for economic and technical cooperation were signed. There were increasing indications, however, of the Afghans displaying an independent, even somewhat pugnacious attitude, vis-a-vis the Soviet Union with regard to the overall economic and commercial relations between the two countries. But perhaps our assessments were wrong,’ Reddy said.

The Indian agents’ dispatch for Indian decision makers in March 1979 suggested a deteriorating situation for Taraki. The anti-government insurrection had slowly but surely expanded over the last few months. By midMarch, almost all the provinces had witnessed serious, extensive and violent anti-government uprisings. This situation culminated in a sudden conflagration on 15 March 1979 in the western city of Herat. What began as a peaceful demonstration by a large number of townspeople against the government’s repression of religious elements quickly blew up into a generalised insurrection in the city and its environs. The city of Herat remained in the hands of the rebels for a good thirty-six hours. Massive reinforcements had to be rushed there by the Afghan government to control the situation. These included Soviet aircraft from across the border. With the USSR’s help, the regime was able to restore formal control over the city by 20 March. Between four thousand and ten thousand people were killed during this uprising and about three hundred Soviet men, women and children were casualties. Even at the end of the month, the situation in and